I changed these 3 Pixel camera settings and finally got the shots I wanted

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Your Pixel camera is a powerful tool (that is leveraged fully by Google Photos) that has a double life: it can both offer nearly pro-level control over your photography, but can also utilize its impressive stack of computational capabilities to dynamically adjust settings both before you take the shot, and use AI algorithms after you take the shot (in the case of Pro Res Zoom, Night Sight, etc.) to provide the best image possible (and Pixel's Camera Coach can help even more).

The problem is that sometimes a Pixel acts too much like a computer and not enough like a camera by making photography decisions that are sometimes not right. But there are several things you can do to make your Pixel act more like a real camera and less like a computer in cases where you're trying to take a particular shot, and the Pixel is frustratingly not behaving as you want. Here are three such tweaks.

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Turn on Focus Peeking

Also, disable auto macro focus

Credit: Brandon Miniman / MakeUseOf

Sometimes it's difficult to know what your Pixel "thinks" you want to focus on. The problem is that you could take a photo, compose it perfectly, only to find later that your camera thought you wanted something in the background to be in focus, when you wanted something in the foreground to be in focus.

There's a simple solution to this, something that pro photographers often use, and it's called Focus Peeking. Focus Peeking uses purple lines to show you where the camera thinks you want to focus. It's still autofocus, but it gives you clarity into what exactly the phone is focusing on so you can adjust your stance, or use tap-to-focus, to get the camera to focus on the right thing. To turn on Focus Peeking, just **go to manual mode** (the three lines in the bottom right corner) **-> tap Focus ->** you're in manual focus mode with **peeking turned on**. Then purple lines will appear in your camera window that show you exactly what the camera is trying to focus on.

In addition, your Pixel has an auto-macro mode turned on by default. What this does is automatically switch to your ultrawide camera which has a shorter minimum focus distance than the other lenses.

The problem with auto-macro mode is that the Pixel is making decisions based on what it thinks your intentions are. You'll find that when trying to take macro shots that the camera might go in and out of macro mode, which makes it very difficult to get the right shot.

Instead, turn off automatic macro mode (**Camera -> Settings -> Macro Focus -> Off**) and adjust focus manually in Pro mode to dial in precisely the right focus distance when you need it (to do that, just enter manual mode with the three lines in the bottom right corner, go to Focus, and adjust the slider as needed). No more having your Pixel go in and out of macro mode and not properly locking onto a focal point, which can be annoying and sometimes prevents you from taking the best shot.

Use pro controls

Get fine-tuned control

Credit: Brandon Miniman / MakeUseOf

Since Pixel 8, Google has added a lot of manual controls to the Pixel for those that want to dial in and specify things like ISO (which changes the camera's sensitivity to light), adjust focus manually (again, focus peeking helps so much for you to precisely pick what the camera is focusing on), as well as adjust shutter speed (important for high-motion or slow-moving shots), tweak white balance, and more.

While the Pixel generally has some of the strongest and best computational photography algorithms to make these decisions for you, sometimes the camera gets it wrong — it makes a scene too dark, it gets the focal point wrong, or it doesn't understand your intention to snap a picture of a fast-moving car where the shutter speed must be very fast. To enter Pro mode, just tap the three lines in the bottom right of the camera app, then you'll see the seven icons appear along the bottom to let you pick which pro control you want to tune.

Shoot in RAW

Like the pros

Credit: Brandon Miniman / MakeUseOf

If you plan to edit your photos, avoid editing the JPEGs produced by your camera. A much better option is to shoot in RAW. While RAW files are significantly larger, they contain the uncompressed data directly from the camera sensor rather than a processed image.

Editing RAW is non-destructive because the software doesn't alter the original file; instead, it saves your adjustments as a set of instructions (often in a "sidecar" file or a database). This allows for a seamless workflow — starting an edit in Lightroom on your tablet and finishing on your PC — without ever degrading the quality of the original pixels.

To capture in RAW while in Pro Mode, just go to the camera **settings cog in the bottom left corner**, tap **Pro**, then **turn on RAW.**

Use natural focal lengths

Stop relying on computational photography

Credit: Brandon Miniman / MakeUseOf

This one might be a bit controversial.

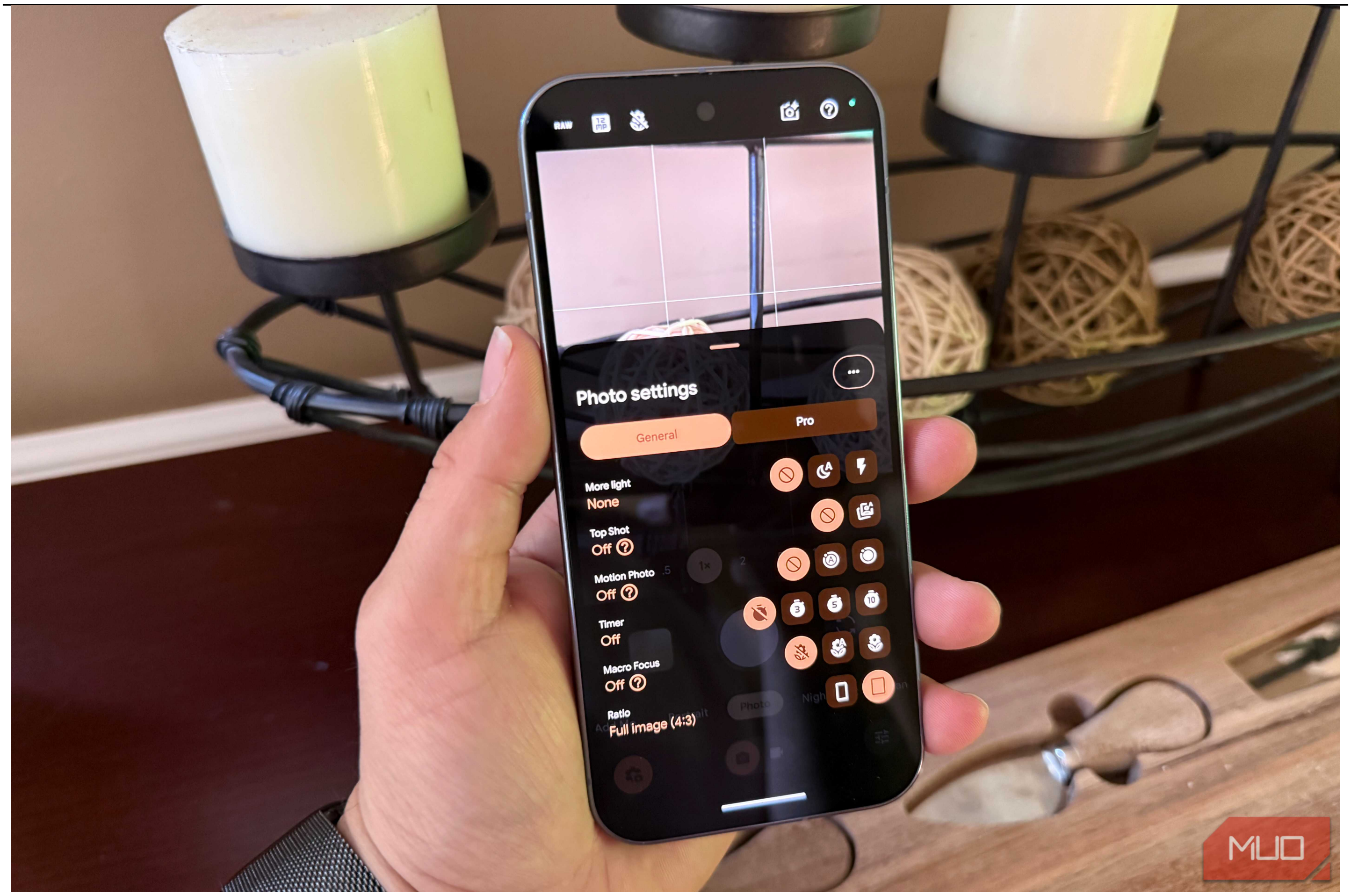
When you tap 0.5x, 1x or 5x on a Pixel 10 Pro, you're using a physical lens at its native focal length — the image is as sharp as the hardware can deliver with respect to the physics of those lenses.

When you drag the slider to anything else, like 1.4x or 4.2x, the Pixel either digitally crops the nearest native length, or it uses computational photography to fake pixel data it doesn't have. By the way, the other focal lengths like 2x and 10x that you see are suggestions. The 2x is a digital crop that basically zooms in on the 1x, and the 10x is doing the same thing by zooming in on the 5x shot, but then applying AI via Pro Res zoom to add image data. Both are fine, but they are reducing image quality by using digital zoom, more or less.

Translation: using in-between focal lengths adds an element of artificiality that might look okay on Instagram, but you're not capturing the true scene. For the most true image data, stick to the native focal distances afforded by the lenses your Pixel actually has, which on the Pixel 10 Pro are 0.5x, 1x, and 5x.

Tap the full potential of the Pixel camera

It's more than just a point and shoot camera



Credit: Brandon Miniman / MakeUseOf

Most of the time, I leave most things in auto, but sometimes using a Pixel can be frustrating when it tries to make decisions for you that aren't right, like when it thinks you're trying to take a close up shot, and it changes to the ultrawide lens without you asking it to do so.

As mentioned, the Pixel can both be a dream point-and-shoot camera that makes all the decisions for you (and it's great at that in most cases), or you can treat it like a real camera and use the pro tools to dial in the correct values that let you capture the photo you envision.

Google Pixel 10 Pro

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The Pixel 10 Pro is Google's highest-end flagship smartphone. It features an improved rear camera system, the Tensor G5 chip, seven years of software updates, and a 6.3" Super Actua display.